

deadlines. In fact, you have to work twice as hard to ensure that the companies/clients hiring you have absolutely no reason to regret employing a freelancer.

STEP 8 Sell Yourself

Be your own boss, and brand manager. While it's important to have an online presence in the form of a website or blog, it's equally important to be aware of competitive pricing and different payment strategies.

Do not charge your clients less because you are working from home. Make enquires pertaining to the market rates for a particular project (say, web-design or coding), and charge them accordingly. Also, do not under-rate or over-rate your skills; and do not undersell or oversell yourself. Be as honest as far as possible.

Tip: To ascertain that Google throws up your site when users enter a certain keyword, make the title of your web page very specific ('Fashion Photographer' or 'Freelance Writer' as the case may be).

Ensure that your site is linked to other prominent ones, by publishing research papers online, being part of active online communities or regularly updating your web log with quality content.



Upgrade Your Skill-sets

When you have time, enrol in training sessions, part-time diploma courses or distance education programmes to upgrade your existing skill sets. With technological advancements, there will be rapid changes in the employment scenario as well.

The IT industry, for instance, is continuously evolving. You may have to invest in software courses, at least once every year, to learn new programming languages, improve your design and editing skills, and so on. Not upgrading your skills periodically would reduce your chances of employment, in any field.



Exercise Regularly

As the maxim goes, health is wealth. Working from home may reduce your travel time but it might also bring to a halt the little exercise you were getting earlier by walking to and from the train or the bus station. To ensure that you give your best to the projects you source, some physical exercise, yoga, and meditation sessions coupled with a balanced diet will help you stay mentally and physically in good shape.

Choose Your Weapon

Browse through the classifieds of your local newspaper. There are plenty of opportunities to 'earn from home', from growing mushrooms, to clicking on advertisements. Web Sites such as, click2freemoney.com, for example, employ people to click on websites and ad banners, in return for cash payment made through PayPal. The site currently pays 40 paise to Rs 2 (or 40 points to 200 points) per click, depending on the advertising revenue. You might have to 'share' some of the moolah with middlemen who charge a 'commission' on daily earnings.

But what makes the difference between a sustainable source of income and a flash-in-the-pan job opportunity is how you go about preparing yourself for a sustained, long-term effort.

As Confucius says, "The mechanic that would perfect his work must first sharpen his tools." So are you ready to hit the home-employment road?■

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